

Politics and Governance in the “Semi-Democracy Era” (1978–1988)

The Constitution of the Kingdom of Thailand, B.E. 2521 (1978), reintroduced the ^{Two System} bicameral system into Thai politics and governance. It provided that Parliament should consist of the House of Representatives, whose members were directly elected by the people, and the Senate, whose members were appointed upon the nomination of the Prime Minister. Civil servants were eligible to serve as senators. The Prime Minister and ministers were not required to be members of Parliament. Moreover, under the transitional provisions, the Senate in its first term was granted equal authority to the House of Representatives in casting votes of no-confidence against the executive. In the first term, the Prime Minister and ministers could be career civil servants, but afterward they could no longer be, though they still did not have to be members of the House of Representatives. At the same time, the Constitution did not prohibit members of the House of Representatives from serving as Prime Minister or ministers. This arrangement revealed that the military still wished to retain control over politics for a time, as they did not trust that the House of Representatives would maintain government stability or prevent ministerial lobbying and conflicts.

Nevertheless, the political framework established by this Constitution led Thai politics into what scholars termed a period of “semi-democracy.” This was an era in which accession to political power was conducted through democratic processes, with regular elections for the House of Representatives held four times—in 1979, 1983, 1986, and 1988. Each time, the Prime Minister was chosen by a majority vote of the House of Representatives, but those selected were influential military leaders—namely General Kriangsak Chomanan and General Prem Tinsulanonda. This pattern continued until, after the general election of 24 July 1988, General Prem Tinsulanonda declined to accept the premiership. The elected House of Representatives then voted by majority

to appoint General Chatichai Choonhavan (then holding the rank of Major General), leader of the Chart Thai Party, as Prime Minister. Ultimately, however, Chatichai's government was overthrown in a coup nearly three years later.

The general election of 22 April 1979 returned 301 members to the House of Representatives through a mixed-member direct election system (up to three representatives per constituency), with a population ratio of 150,000 people per representative and a four-year term. Voter turnout was 9,913,401, representing 43.90%. This election was held under the transitional provisions of the 1978 Constitution, which meant that political parties had not yet been legally established. In practice, however, groups were organized and campaigns conducted under the names of political parties, alongside independent candidacies. In total, 14 political groups won representation, alongside 44 independents. The largest group was the Social Action Group with 85 seats, followed by the Chart Thai Group with 42, the Democrat Group with 34, the Thai Population Group with 32, the Seritham Group with 22, and others in descending order. After the election, General Kriangsak Chomanan, who had not run for office, was supported by Parliament to form a government on 12 May 1979, with backing from several groups such as Agriculture and Society, Seritham, Democratic Action, National People, Ruam Thai, and independent MPs. However, his government lasted less than a year. On 29 February 1980, General Kriangsak addressed Parliament on the difficulties faced by his government and announced his resignation as Prime Minister. Without a new election, the House of Representatives elected General Prem Tinsulanonda as Prime Minister on 3 March 1980.

General Prem Tinsulanonda went on to serve as Thailand's Prime Minister for three consecutive terms, totaling about eight years, without forming his own political party or contesting elections. During his tenure, he dissolved Parliament three times and survived two attempted

coups. The first dissolution occurred on 19 March 1983 after the House rejected the proposal to extend the transitional provisions of the 1978 Constitution, leading to a general election on 18 April 1983. That election filled 324 seats in the House of Representatives under the same mixed-member direct election system (up to three per district), with the 150,000 population ratio. Law also required political parties to field candidates in no fewer than half of all constituencies, though individual candidates could still run independently as transitional provisions remained in effect. Voter turnout was 12,295,339, or 50.76%. The Chart Thai Party, led by Major General Pramarn Adireksarn, won the most seats with 110, followed by the Social Action Party under M.R. Kukrit Pramoj with 99, and the Democrat Party under Bhichai Rattakul with 56. After the election, the Social Action Party and the Democrat Party, joined by smaller parties, formed a coalition and re-elected General Prem as Prime Minister.

Prem's second dissolution of Parliament took place on 1 May 1986 after his government lost a vote on a Royal Decree concerning land transport. This forced new elections on 27 July 1986. That election returned 347 MPs under the same system but now without transitional provisions—thus, all candidates had to run under political parties, each fielding no fewer than half of all constituencies. Turnout reached 16,070,957 voters (61.43%). Out of 16 parties contesting, 15 won seats. The Democrats secured the largest share with 100 seats, followed by Chart Thai with 63, Social Action with 53, and Sahaphum with 34. The three largest parties, along with the Rassadorn Party (18 seats), formed a coalition and again voted Prem into the premiership. However, his third term lasted less than two years. On 29 April 1988, he dissolved Parliament after internal problems in the Democrat Party, where the “10 January Group” MPs rejected the government's Copyright Bill, causing it to fail. The Democrats withdrew from the coalition in consequence.

The subsequent general election was held on 24 July 1988, with 357 MPs elected under the same system and rules. Turnout reached 16,944,931, or 63.56%. Fifteen parties won seats, with Chart Thai winning the most at 87, followed by Social Action with 54, Democrats with 48, Ruam Thai with 35, and Thai Population with 31. This election marked another turning point in Thai politics: as Prem declined to accept the premiership, the House voted to make Major General Chatichai Choonhavan, leader of the Chart Thai Party (which held the most seats), the new Prime Minister. He became the first party leader, elected MP, and parliamentary choice to serve as Prime Minister since the events of 6 October 1976. This signaled that the “semi-democracy” system was no longer acceptable for Thailand’s political development at that time.